

Under Trial

The GM crops that are being tested in India for release



CAULIFLOWER
Sungro Seeds and Nunhems India.



RICE
Bayer Bioscience, Avesthagen, Mahyco and Metahelix Life Science.



TOMATO
Avesthagen, IARI and Mahyco.



GROUNDNUT
ICRISAT



CABBAGE
Nunhems



POTATO
Central Potato Research Institute



CORN
Monsanto, Pioneer Overseas and Dow Agrosciences



SORGHUM
National Research Centre for Sorghum



OKRA
Mahyco



BRINJAL
Mahyco, Bejo Sheetal Seeds, Sungro Seeds, University of Agricultural Sciences and the Tamil Nadu Agricultural Univ.



MUSTARD
Delhi University

The Global Spread

Developing countries are taking the plunge in growing GM crops

The global march of biotech in farming is slow but steady. The number of countries electing to grow biotech crops has increased steadily from six in 1996, the first year of commercialisation, to 18 in 2003 and 25 in 2008. And this is a historic milestone for the advocates of biotech crops. In 2008, the global hectareage of biotech crops continued to grow strongly reaching 125 million hectares, up from 114.3 million hectares in 2007.

The USA has the largest area—62.5 million ha—growing soyabean, maize, cotton, canola, squash, papaya, alfalfa, and sugarbeet, followed by Argentina—21.0 million ha—with soyabean, maize and cotton. Brazil with the same crops as Argentina is in the third slot—15.8 million ha. India has become the

fourth largest adopter of biotech crops in 2008 with cotton alone occupying 7.6 million ha. Canada is in the fifth slot, growing canola, maize, soyabean, sugarbeet in a marginally less area. China is in the sixth slot, growing cotton, tomato, poplar, petunia, papaya, sweet pepper in half the area covered in India by

GM FOODS HAVE GROWING ACCEPTABILITY IN THE WEST



AP PHOTO

sues. "There is also the threat to future seeds and Indian agriculture coming under the control of multinational companies and charging of exorbitant prices for the seeds from Indian farmers," says the All India Kisan Sabha. "The monopoly of MNCs like Monsanto over the seeds is another major concern, as seeds are no longer in the public domain as these are now the intellectual property of these multinationals." The irony is that this argument may not hold good in the case of Bt brinjal as several Indian research institutions are closely associated with the research and testing.

There is valid scepticism about the integrity of the approval process. This is why renowned molecular biologist Pushpa M. Bhargava, the member appointed to the committee by the Supreme Court, in the light of public interest litigation on the functioning of the GEAC, to oversee matters of the

GEAC, emphasises that its proceedings fall far short of the rigour required before passing something as contentious and complex as a genetically modified food crop. "It is a disaster. It is unethical. No time was given to us as members to review the findings. Why was it rushed? I had suggested to them to invite all stakeholders and have a scientific discussion on the matter. But they avoided it," says an enraged Bhargava.

What the moderates among the critics argue is that not enough is known at this point in time about the all round impact of GM crops to clear their release into the environment. Much more rigorous testing is needed before this can be done. They also point out that studies on Bt crops show that there are potential health hazards in bio-engineered foods. Animals ingesting GM food have shown problems in growth, organ de-

"It will help millions of brinjal farmers suffering from the havoc caused by the pest and increase incomes. RAJU BARWALE, Managing Director, Mahyco"